# An Eye for Detail

**Consultant Dheeya Somaiya is bringing fine art down from its unreachable ivory tower and onto the walls of contemporary, everyday Indian homes**

By **RIDHI KALE**

She was 25, starting out at Aicon Gallery in New York, putting together a high profile collection for a client in Singapore, a modern artwork by S.H. Raza was instrumental in clinching the deal. That's when Dheeya Somaiya realised, there is a distinct difference between a house that contains art and a home that lives with it. She also understood that for the uninitiated, navigating the art market can feel overwhelming. She then honed her curatorial eye at institutional heavyweights like DAG and the NMACC Art House. Today, the Mumbai-based art consultant runs an independent advisory practice that decodes and recommends art for collectors, architects and homeowners.

**Mindset Matters**

Having started her career in New York before transitioning back to Mumbai, Somaiya has observed a stark contrast in collector DNA. "In the US, collectors are traditionally more hands-on," says Somaiya. "They actively track auctions and study art movements." In India, that proactive itch is catching up, but an institutional gap remains. "Local buyers still lean heavily on their interior designers. There is immense room for Indian homeowners to take direct ownership of their acquisition journey."

**Ancient Avant-Garde**

Over the years she realised that recontextualising heritage requires a deliberate subversion of expectations; in fact, this is the philosophy Somaiya championed at her recent NMACC show, *Cloth and Canvas*. To integrate traditional narrative forms like Pichhwais or miniatures into contemporary spaces, presentation is everything. "We showcased traditional works using contemporary colour palettes and non-traditional hanging methods," she explains. By viewing ancestral craftsmanship through an architectural lens, classic Indian art anchors a modern room.

**Curation Equation**

For Somaiya, this artistic confluence continues inside sleek, minimalist apartments. Here, she believes, traditional pieces can thrive through strategic framing and asymmetry. Traditional frames act as ornamental boundaries that elevate historical status, while contemporary frames serve as unobtrusive bridges to modern interiors. Layouts should also master negative space. "Place a delicate miniature off-centre on a large console table and leave empty space beside it," she advises. This injects instant breathing room.

**The New Guard**

So, if you are ready to transition from commercial prints to original investments, Somaiya suggests stepping away from the mainstream. Look to graduate shows like the JJ School of Art or pioneering residency foundations like Mumbai's Space118. "Imagine being a patron to an artist at the absolute genesis of their career. That is where you start."

As the market surges, Somaiya flags narrative textile art, using yarn, silk and stitching to tell visual stories, as the definitive medium to watch. But wherever you source your canvas, beware of the ultimate design crime, poor illumination. "You can buy the perfect work, but if the lighting is wrong, it defeats the purpose entirely," she warns. "Proper illumination is the final brushstroke."